

Bernini, Borromini and da Cortona

Prominent baroque architects included Gian Lorenzo Bernini (1598–1680), Francesco Borromini (1599–1667) and Pietro da Cortona (1596/7–1669). Early on, they worked together on the Palazzo Barberini, which had been started by the architect Carlo Maderno, but they became fierce rivals. Bernini was also the greatest sculptor of the baroque, as well as a painter and poet; his sculpture and buildings epitomize the flamboyance, theatricality and splendour of the period. Among many prestigious commissions were his contributions to St Peter's in Rome: the large piazza in front of the basilica, an immense gilt-bronze baldachin (canopy) over St Peter's tomb inside, and the decoration of the four huge piers supporting the dome, plus grand statues. Borromini, originally a mason, challenged tradition with audacious combinations of elements and proportions. Cortona's church of Santi Luca e Martina (opposite, 1634) was one of the first curved façades in baroque Rome, with closely packed composite orders, while his Santa Maria della Pace has an unexpected, temple-like semi-oval portico.

